
From Connoisseurship to Networks: Mobilities of Potters and Painters in South Italy Red-Figure Pottery Production (450–300 BCE)

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Abstract

Mobility among craftspeople played a significant role in the ancient Mediterranean world. While literary sources frequently inform about the movement of sculptors and painters, tracing the temporary or definitive migrations of ceramic producers remains considerably more problematic. For Classical Athens and Southern Italy, the displacement of potters and vase-painters has traditionally been inferred from stylistic analysis yet seldom substantiated through explicit and replicable analytical frameworks. This paper tackles this issue by integrating established connoisseurship approaches with Social Network Analysis, offering a critical assessment of archaeological and art-historical sources as foundations for historical network research, following other recent attempt aimed at integrating ancient Athenian pottery and Network studies (Hasaki and Cline 2018).

The SNA developed is based on an extensive dataset of vase-painters' attributions ("hands") defined through Morellian connoisseurship (Beazley 1963; Trendall 1967; Trendall and Cambitoglou 1978). Although scattered across large and heterogeneous catalogues, these attributions have been intended as relational data, allowing the reconstruction of patterns of collaboration, stylistic transmission, and workshop organization. Over 550 painters active in Southern Italy during the fifth and fourth century BCE are represented as nodes within an innovative visualization for this kind of artisanal dynamics in the ancient Greek world.

Network-based visualizations expose structural configurations that are difficult to perceive through traditional qualitative methods alone, such as intermediary workshops, connections bridging regional figurative tradition, and clusters linked to technical and stylistic innovation. When integrated with spatial analysis, SNA facilitates a clearer distinction between the circulation of ceramic products and the physical movement of craftspeople, thereby refining interpretations of artisan mobility, knowledge exchange, and economic behavior.

From a methodological perspective, this paper demonstrates the heuristic potential of network thinking (and visualization) for ancient art history and archaeology, offering fresh perspectives on enduring debates concerning mobility, collaboration, and connectivity in the ancient Greek crafting world.

Beazley, John D. 1963. *Attic Red-Figure Vase-Painters*. 2nd ed. Oxford: Clarendon Press.

Hasaki, Eleni, and Diane Harris Cline. 2018. "Social Network Analysis and Connoisseurship in the Study of Athenian Potters' Communities." In *Reconstructing Scales of Production in*

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the Ancient Greek World: Producers, Processes, Products, People, edited by Eleni Hasaki and Martin Bentz, 59–80. Proceedings of the 19th International Congress of Classical Archaeology, vol. 8, Cologne/Bonn, May 22–26, 2018. Heidelberg.

Trendall, Arthur Dale. 1967. *The Red-Figured Vases of Lucania, Campania, and Sicily*. Oxford: Clarendon Press.

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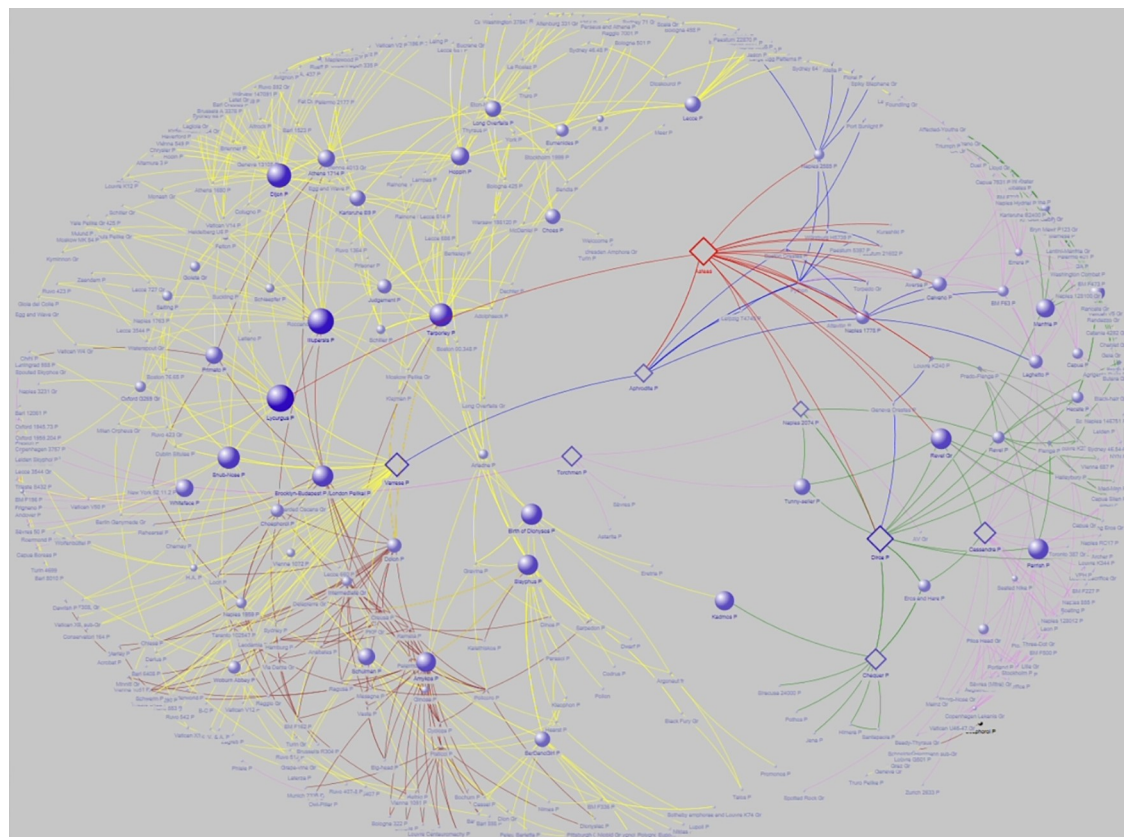
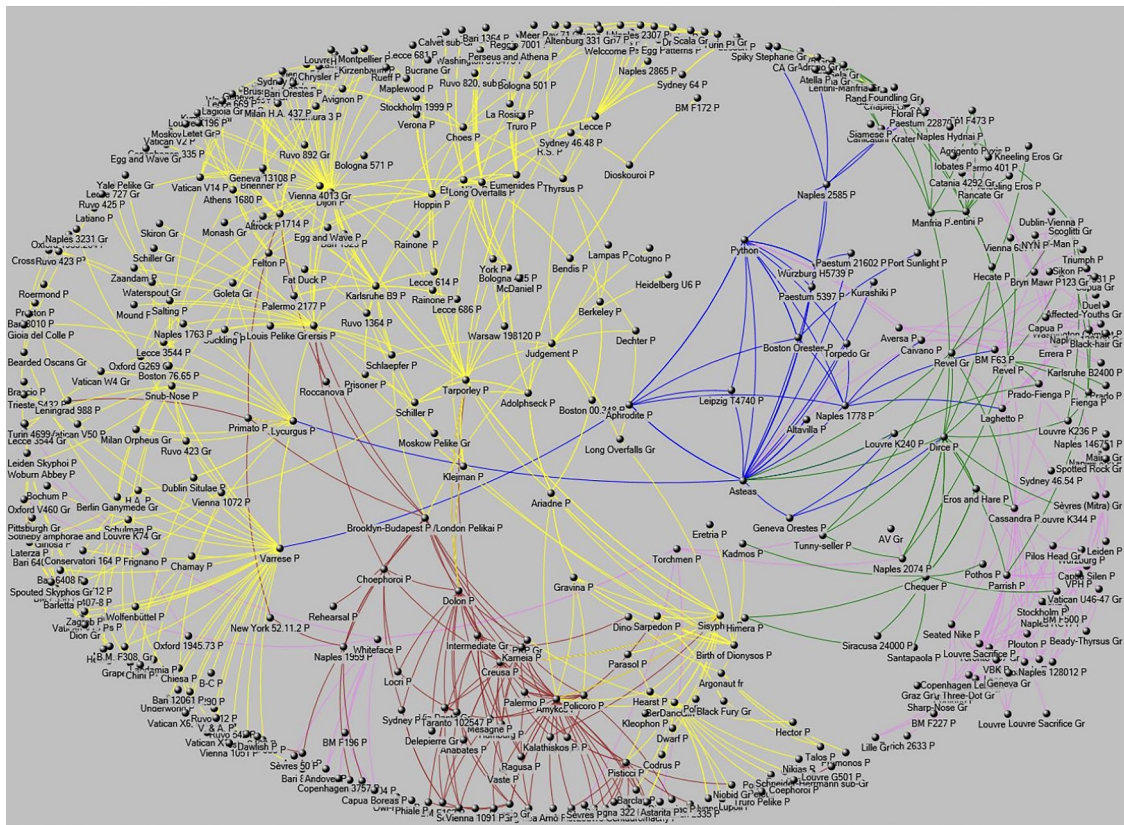


Fig. 1 Social Network Analysis of South Italian red-figure painters/workshops. © A.G.A.T.H.O.C.L.E.S. project